population of displaced people joined the more than 400,000 Rohingya who already live in camps and informal settlements on the Bangladesh side of the border. The international community expressed deep concern about this explosion of communal animosity. Protests from the Muslim world were particularly strident. In the aftermath, there were claims of crimes against humanity and even genocide (Maung Zarni and Cowley 2014; Bauer 2015; also Southwick 2015).

Elsewhere in Myanmar, there was concern that the violence might spread. Cities like Yangon and Mandalay, and countless other towns across the country, have large and well-established Muslim populations. The perception that the Muslim community is large and growing adds to the popular anxieties that are inflamed by hardline Buddhist chauvinist rhetoric. Around the country, the symbols of the 969 movement and of the Committee for the Protection of Race and Religion (commonly known by its Burmese acronym "MaBaTha") are very common. Through 2013 there was more violence, with significant episodes in Meiktila, in central Myanmar, and at Lashio in the Shan State. Even though the level of violence has dropped since 2014, animosity towards Muslims remains a significant factor in local and national political relations. The NLD and USDP did not endorse Muslim candidates at the 2015 election. And many Muslim voters who were eligible to cast a vote in 2010 found themselves disenfranchised by new rules about voter eligibility.

Other religious minorities face different challenges. Most of Myanmar's Christian communities are found in the Kayin, Kachin and Chin States where ethnic identity has, for many people, been fused to their Christian faith. Strong Baptist and Catholic congregations exert influence on local politics, often in defiance of the expectations of Myanmar's Bamar Buddhist majority. Religion and politics are still fused in many minds, especially across the borderlands. The other religious minorities — such as Hindus, Sikhs and Jews — have relatively small populations, around which there tend to be fewer political skirmishes. Nonetheless any consideration of religious conflict still involves these visible minorities, who may also feel alienated from Myanmar's Buddhist majority culture and the powerful interests that it relies on for support.